Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Wordsworth's "[My heart leaps up when I behold]"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of theme of Wordsworth's "[My heart leaps up when I behold]," include

anaphora,
metonymy,
rhyme,
rhythm,
speaker,
symbol,
synecdoche,
tetrameter,
theme, and
tone.

The contestant should dwell on the pivotal line "[t]he Child is father of the Man" (line 7) while he or she addresses the lyric poem's theme regarding a lifelong enthusiasm for natural beauty: What we discover as meaningful when we are young gives deeper meaning to what we are while we mature.

The young writer might recognize the speaker's encountering of the rainbow during his youth in either or both its symbolic or metonymic (or synecdochic) role as a terminus connecting forward through a person's life. The modal verb phrase "could wish" (line 8) places the speaker in mid life between childhood and old age, and sets up "natural piety" (line 9)—first introduced by the speaker's childhood enthusiastic response to the beauty of a rainbow—as a lifelong aesthetic regarding beauty.

The student's analysis of the connection stretching across a person's life (maybe a poet's life) as a continuum of inspiration would reflect his or her own connection of this poem with the sample of Wordsworth's poetry encountered this season.